
Fish! Sticks

A Remarkable Way to Adapt to Changing Times and Keep Your Work Fresh

Important Insights & Action Guide

Based on the book by
Stephen C. Lundin, Harry Paul, and John Christensen

The Question, and the Answer

The central question. Once you have made a real, positive change, how do you keep it? Not how you start something new, but how you stop a good thing from quietly fading once the excitement of the launch wears off.

The authors' answer. The fanfare that launches a change — what the authors call *external energy* — can never sustain it. Lasting change runs on a different fuel, *natural energy*, which comes only from personal choice. That energy is generated and renewed through three ongoing commitments — **Find It, Live It, Coach It** — because commitment itself is only an abstraction until it becomes action.

THE TWO ENERGIES

External energy launches a change — events, training, posters, props. It catches attention, then runs out.

Natural energy sustains a change. It comes from people's own commitment and choice, and it never runs out on its own.

THE THREE COMMITMENTS

Find It — make the vision personal, through conversation.

Live It — act on the daily vision moments.

Coach It — give and take honest feedback, for the vision.

The Diagnosis: Why Change Fades

01 Starting a change is easy; keeping it is the hard part.

Launching a change and sustaining one call for completely different principles, and this book is about the second, neglected half. Almost all the effort, budget, and celebration go into the kickoff; almost none goes into the far harder work of what happens a year later.

WHY IT MATTERS

The year-later moment is exactly when most good changes quietly die — so the phase everyone ignores is the phase that decides whether the change survives.

IN THE STORY

Rhonda inherits a hospital ward that Madeline had transformed into the crown jewel of the hospital. Less than a year later she is watching its energy leak away: a gifted aide asks to transfer, nurses chat in a patient's room while the call light blinks, help is slow to arrive.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Plan attention and effort for the “keep it alive” phase, not just the launch. Assume the hard part comes after the applause.

REMEMBER *A change you cannot sustain is not really a change.*

02 External energy launches; natural energy sustains.

The fanfare of a launch — meetings, training, contests, buttons, posters — is external energy. It is excellent for catching attention in a busy world and useless for the long haul. What lasts is natural energy, and natural energy comes from personal choice, not from props.

WHY IT MATTERS

If a culture runs on external things, it collapses the moment the props are removed or the novelty simply wears off — which it always does.

IN THE STORY

Takara Too, a small sushi restaurant, has kept a line of customers waiting in the cold every night for four years with no gimmicks — while lavishly decorated rivals a few blocks away sit nearly empty. Great decor was not enough; a living, valued experience was.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Stop feeding a change with more events and props. Start generating energy from within, through people's own commitment.

REMEMBER *Balloons deflate. Choice does not.*

03 The pull back to old ways begins immediately.

The instant you change anything, a “gravity pull” back toward old habits begins. It shows up as distraction, busyness, boredom, forgetfulness, cynicism, even quiet sabotage — and you cannot feel it while the energy is still high.

WHY IT MATTERS

It means backsliding is not a personal failure or a surprise; it is closer to physics. Expecting the pull completely changes how calmly and steadily you respond to it.

IN THE STORY

Rhonda’s friend Margot tells her the decline would be happening even under the beloved Madeline. The problem is predictable and universal, not a sign that Rhonda is unfit to lead.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Treat sustaining as an ongoing practice rather than a one-time fix, and learn to notice the early, quiet signs of the pull before they harden.

REMEMBER *Sustaining a vision is a practice you renew, not a phase you finish.*

The Three Commitments

04 Find It — make the vision your own.

An organizational vision is written broadly, in abstract language, because it must speak to many stakeholders at once. Your “it” is different: your own focused, specific, personal piece of that vision. A vision belongs to no one until each person claims a part of it.

WHY IT MATTERS

People protect what is theirs. A vision nobody has personalized is just words on a card, and words on a card generate no energy.

IN THE STORY

Asked what he is committed to, the nurse Chad starts with “the stuff on the card,” then finds his real it: patient contact that is compassionate, intelligent, and light-hearted rather than stiff and distant.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Ask people not what the vision says, but what their own piece of it is — and help them name it.

REMEMBER *Draft the vision for everyone; draft your “it” just for you.*

05 You find your “it” only through conversation — and the conversation itself creates energy.

The one and only way to find your it is to talk about your work, honestly, with the people you work beside. And here is the engine of the whole method: simply having those conversations releases natural energy, because people are talking about what matters most to them.

WHY IT MATTERS

It locates the true source of the energy that sustains change. It is not the poster and not the slogan — it is real conversation, repeated often.

IN THE STORY

Rhonda starts hanging around the break room, coming early for the night shift and staying late for the evening staff, simply talking with people like Ping and Juan. Without anyone naming why, the old energy begins to return.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Carve out regular, protected time for real conversations about work; do not try to have them on the fly.

REMEMBER *The energy you are missing is on the far side of a real conversation.*

06 Live It — act on vision moments, and mind who you are being.

Once you have found your it, you live it by acting on “vision moments” — the small, naturally occurring chances each day to bring the vision to life. Living it is not only the work you do; it is who you are being while you do it. Commitment changes what you are able to notice: commit to something big and you start seeing openings you would otherwise miss.

WHY IT MATTERS

It turns a vision from a wall poster into daily behavior. Vision moments are where the abstraction actually touches another human being.

IN THE STORY

The aide Juan sits with the frail wife of a stroke patient, takes her hand, shows her the little hidden fish, and tells her she is family now — so she goes home and rests, and the night staff is spared. One quiet vision moment.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Look for the small openings to *be* the vision, not merely to do the job.

REMEMBER *You are the vision. So live it.*

07 Coach It — give and take honest feedback in every direction.

You cannot see yourself in action or feel your effect on others, so a vision needs feedback. Everyone is a coach; anyone may coach anyone, regardless of rank. You may accept or reject a piece of coaching, but you owe it a genuine hearing first — and it is never an ego trip.

WHY IT MATTERS

Coaching is the glue and the fuel: the small, constant corrections that keep a vision from drifting. Without it, even sincere commitment slowly fades.

IN THE STORY

A newly hired waiter, Taeko, coaches Ishi — the owner — about her curt tone. She blushes, apologizes, and the exchange about a questionable tuna becomes a lesson in how they treat each other, which mattered more than the fish.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Make giving and receiving feedback a shared responsibility, not a manager's privilege.

REMEMBER *Coach for the vision, never for the ego.*

08 Commitment becomes real only through action.

Commitment on its own is an abstraction. Find it, live it, and coach it are the concrete actions that turn commitment into something real. This is the book's central claim, and it is why the three principles are verbs, not values.

WHY IT MATTERS

It gives you a test. You can stop debating who is “bought in” and simply watch what people do.

IN THE STORY

The whole story bends toward this line — and it is proved when the nurses stop talking about commitment and build a Commitment Gate, a vision-moment photo contest, and a coaching-card chain.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Judge commitment by what people do, not by what they say they value.

REMEMBER *Commitment is an abstraction until you act.*

The Deeper Truths

09 Symbols and rituals are conversation-starters, not the source of energy.

The team first believes the external props — fish, posters, pins — are the problem, then reaches a subtler truth: the symbol is not the energy, but it keeps the conversations going, and the conversations are the energy.

WHY IT MATTERS

It resolves a real tension. You do not have to choose between meaningful symbols and internal energy; used well, a symbol prompts the very conversation that regenerates commitment.

IN THE STORY

When a new boss orders the fish badges gone, the staff moves the fish *inside* their clothing — then later adopts a lapel pin (inspired by a Ritz-Carlton article) precisely because an outsider's question forces them to re-state what they believe.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Keep a symbol only if it triggers a conversation; retire it the moment it becomes invisible decoration.

REMEMBER *A symbol earns its place by starting a conversation.*

10 The philosophy must hold the whole of being human — not just fun.

"Choose your attitude" was never a demand for relentless cheer. The deeper claim underneath the Fish! idea is about being fully present and fully human — which sometimes means sitting honestly with sorrow.

WHY IT MATTERS

A culture that cannot make room for grief, and for the full range of temperaments, is not a real culture; it is a performance that shatters the first time real life arrives.

IN THE STORY

When Rhonda's stepdaughter is killed by a drunk driver, the rigid Ms. Scalpel — who lost her own husband — quietly organizes all of the family's care and insists that grief is exactly as it should be. This, she says, is the chance to prove it was never just about fun.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Let the culture flex to hold hard seasons and different kinds of people; never equate the vision with a single upbeat mood.

REMEMBER *If it cannot hold sorrow, it was never real.*

11 Blaze your own trail — more study can be resistance.

The principles are old and borrowed, but your application of them is yours alone to discover. Asking for a step-by-step list, right at the moment it is time to act, is a natural form of resistance.

WHY IT MATTERS

A borrowed how-to guarantees you are walking someone else's path. Your own path appears only as you walk it — the idea Ishi borrows from the mythologist Joseph Campbell.

IN THE STORY

Ishi refuses to give the nurses a to-do list — “take the step that does not yet exist” — and, freed from the search for a template, they go home and invent their own Commitment Gate, contest, and card chain.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

When you catch yourself gathering one more example instead of acting, take the first real step instead.

REMEMBER *The path appears only as you walk it.*

The Essential Stories

Takara Too and the four-year line

A small, understated sushi restaurant keeps customers waiting in the cold every night for four years, while richly decorated rivals nearby sit empty. It is the book's living proof that a valued, sustained experience — not decor — is what keeps people coming back.

The diet Dr. Pepper and the tray of reading glasses

A waiter walks a block to a deli for a soda that is not on the menu; another appears within seconds with six pairs of reading glasses when a guest forgets hers. Small, unbidden acts — vision moments — that quietly define the whole experience.

The fish that went inside

Ordered to remove their fish badges, the nurses instead pin the fish *inside* their clothing as a sign that the commitment now lives in them, not on their lapels — the book's clearest image of moving energy from the prop to the person.

The tuna and the coaching that grew

A brand-new waiter coaches the veteran owner about her sharp tone; she apologizes, and a disagreement about a fish becomes a lesson in how they treat each other. Coaching, done for the vision, flows in every direction.

Anne's death and Ms. Scalpel's response

When tragedy strikes Rhonda's family, the story's most rigid character organizes all the care and insists grief belongs. It is the moment the philosophy proves it can hold the whole of a human life, not just the cheerful parts.

Joseph Campbell and the path you cannot see

If you can see your whole path laid out in front of you, Campbell says, you can be sure it is someone else's — your own is created only in the act of walking it. The book's argument for acting rather than endlessly studying.

The dedication: Beth Anne Lundin

At the back of the book, the author reveals that his own daughter, a young set designer, was killed by a drunk driver — and that a colleague at her memorial said, "Beth was Fish." The true loss folded into the fable, and the reason its subject is finally so much larger than work.

Definitions & Distinctions

External energy

The fanfare that launches a change — events, training, contests, posters, props. Effective for catching attention, but only in the short term.

Natural energy

The self-renewing energy that sustains a change. It comes from personal choice and commitment, and is released whenever people talk about what genuinely matters to them.

The gravity pull of old ways

The steady force pulling people back to old habits the instant a change begins — felt as distraction, busyness, boredom, cynicism, forgetfulness, or sabotage.

The vision vs. your “it”

The *vision* is the broad, shared statement written for many stakeholders. Your *it* is your own focused, personal piece of that vision — found only through conversation.

Vision moment

A small, naturally occurring, everyday chance to bring the vision to life through how you act and who you are being in that instant.

Real / fierce conversation

An honest exchange about the work and how you do it. *Real* because it refuses pretense; *fierce* because how we spend our working lives is too important to be handled lightly.

Coaching

Giving and receiving honest feedback in all directions to keep the vision strong — open to everyone regardless of rank, always for the vision and never for the ego, with the right to accept or reject but the duty to listen first.

Attrition vs. turnover

Attrition is the normal, unavoidable loss of people to moves, promotions, and life. *Turnover* is good people leaving because something is wrong — preventable, and a warning sign.

Redecorate vs. real change

The question Phil leaves with Rhonda: if the whole atmosphere depends on toys, badges, and posters, did you make a lasting change — or did you just redecorate?

Actionable Ideas

01 Start real conversations about work.

WHAT TO DO

Regularly ask colleagues open questions about what you are creating together and each person's place in it — for example: What are we creating here with our life energy? What is your own piece of it? What is at stake for you? When in your day do you know you are living the vision?

WHEN TO USE IT

As the first move when energy is fading, and then as a permanent, recurring habit.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

A vision that has gone abstract and impersonal, and a workplace whose energy is quietly leaking away.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

People can name their own “it,” and the room feels more alive at the end of the conversation than it did at the start.

CAUTION

Do not open with jargon like “find your it” — it sounds strange cold; just have the conversation. And do not squeeze these in on the fly; protect the time for them.

02 Notice and act on vision moments.

WHAT TO DO

Each day, look for one small chance to *be* the vision rather than merely do the task — and take it.

WHEN TO USE IT

Continuously, inside the flow of ordinary work.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

The vision stays a poster on the wall while nothing actually changes in day-to-day behavior.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

Small, unprompted acts of the vision become common, and they turn out to be contagious.

CAUTION

Vision moments are spontaneous and genuine — do not stage them for show. Forced or posed “moments” ring hollow and teach the wrong lesson.

03 Build a two-way coaching habit.

WHAT TO DO

Make it everyone's job to give and to accept honest feedback about how you work and who you are being — with the right to accept or reject, but the duty to listen first.

WHEN TO USE IT

Ongoing, and especially the moment someone slips out of the vision.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Drift goes uncorrected because no one can see themselves clearly or feel their own effect on others.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

Feedback flows in every direction without defensiveness, and everyone understands it is for the vision.

CAUTION

Coaching must never become an ego trip or a status move. The instant it is about being right, it stops working.

04 Use symbols as conversation triggers — and retire the dead ones.

WHAT TO DO

Keep a symbol or ritual only if it prompts people to explain and re-commit; treat outsiders' questions about it as fuel for that conversation.

WHEN TO USE IT

Whenever you are tempted to add a new prop, or to fight for an old one.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Two opposite failures: over-relying on external props, or throwing away ones that still do real work.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

Symbols reliably spark the conversations that regenerate commitment.

CAUTION

If a symbol has faded into invisible background, it has become decoration — let it go.

05 Integrate new people on purpose.

WHAT TO DO

Explicitly bring newcomers and temporary staff into the vision through conversation. Do not assume they will absorb it from the atmosphere.

WHEN TO USE IT

At every hire, and whenever the team's makeup has changed.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Turnover, and capable "outsiders" who never feel part of what the team has built.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

New people can name their own "it" and do not feel they arrived after the party ended.

CAUTION

Politeness is not integration. Being respectful to a newcomer while quietly leaving them out will still lose them — exactly what nearly happened with Juan.

06 Take the first step instead of studying one more example.

WHAT TO DO

When the principles are clear, act — craft your own version in your own setting rather than copying someone else's playbook.

WHEN TO USE IT

The moment you notice yourself asking for more examples before doing anything.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Analysis used as avoidance, and a borrowed path that was never yours to begin with.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You have taken a concrete, imperfect, first action that actually fits your culture.

CAUTION

Learn to tell genuine learning apart from resistance dressed up as diligence.

07 When persuading a skeptic, bring evidence.

WHAT TO DO

Meet a data-minded or doubtful stakeholder with facts, figures, and findings — and make the effort to see the situation through their eyes.

WHEN TO USE IT

When someone with real power dismisses the culture as fluff.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

A culture that reads as soft or frivolous to people who trust numbers.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

The skeptic is moved by evidence — as Ms. Scalpel was, once she saw the ward's patient- and staff-satisfaction data.

CAUTION

Do not argue from enthusiasm alone — and do not write the skeptic off; handled well, they may become your strongest ally.

Quick Reference

The question: Once you've made a good change, how do you keep it from fading?

The answer: External energy launches change; natural energy sustains it — and natural energy is renewed through three commitments that turn abstract commitment into action.

THE TWO ENERGIES

- **External** — events, props, fanfare. Grabs attention, then runs out.
- **Natural** — personal choice and commitment. Renews itself.

THE THREE COMMITMENTS

- **Find It** — make the vision personal. *How:* talk about your work, honestly and often, until you can name your own “it.”
- **Live It** — act on daily vision moments. *How:* mind who you are being, and take the small chances to be the vision.
- **Coach It** — give and take honest feedback. *How:* anyone coaches anyone, for the vision, never for the ego; listen before you decide.

WATCH FOR THE GRAVITY PULL

Distraction • busyness • boredom • forgetfulness • cynicism • sabotage. It starts the moment you change, so keep renewing the practice.

REMEMBER *Commitment is only an abstraction until you act. So find it, live it, and coach it.*